

Welcome to SD5009 Research + Academic Writing

“How to Transform a Designer's Ideas and Curiosity into Academic Manners”

Time: May 26 - July 14 | 13 Sessions (Tuesday & Thursday)

Location:

- Main Lecture Room: HJ304
- Tutorial Rooms: V1122, V1123, V1124 and V1014.

Instructors (E-mail):

- **Coordinator + Teacher:** [Prof. Angus Donald CAMPBELL](mailto:angus.campbell@polyu.edu.hk) - angus.campbell@polyu.edu.hk
- **Co-Teacher:** [Dr. Luis VEGA](mailto:luis.vega@polyu.edu.hk) - luis.vega@polyu.edu.hk
- **Part-Time Visiting Lecturer:** [Dr. Jenn Y LEE](mailto:jenn-y.lee@polyu.edu.hk) - jenn-y.lee@polyu.edu.hk
- **Part-Time Visiting Lecturer:** [Ms. Bharati DAS](mailto:dr-bharati.das@connect.polyu.hk), dr-bharati.das@connect.polyu.hk

Course Description

The course entitled "Research and Academic Writing (SD 5009): How to Transform Designer's Ideas and Curiosity into Academic Manners" is designed to equip designers with the critical thinking skills necessary to articulate their creative ideas, concepts, and processes in an academic context. Participants will learn a structured and systematic approach to become academic writers or researchers.

To be an effective and competent design researcher, it is essential to possess theoretical, practical, and methodological knowledge of how to organise research contexts, issues, and problems, as well as research and project questions, design and research project processes, and resulting outcomes. Therefore, the objectives of this course are twofold: first, to identify research issues and problems by formulating appropriate academic research questions in a relevant empirical manner, and second, to develop research outcomes with a logical flow that can be understood by other stakeholders.

Throughout the course, participants will follow a series of academic writing foundations, starting with creating research interests, conducting literature reviews, identifying suitable research questions, searching for relevant and rigorous research methodologies, and summarizing findings and implications. In the process, participants may encounter challenges reconciling the designer's abductive reasoning with the academic researcher's inductive and deductive reasoning. However, this process will be rewarding and will enable participants to become more logical designers or design researchers in their future careers.

The course will provide participants with three essential takeaways. First, it will provide a lesson on the basic content and structure of academic writing in design subjects. Second, it will offer practical know-how on transforming a design project into design research. Third, it will suggest a positive direction for overcoming language barriers and achieving better logical flow in critical and systemic thinking.

To achieve these goals, the course will employ three major activities. First, a series of accessible lectures will cover the fundamental academic writing knowledge and practice. Second, tutorial sessions will provide more detailed information and support for developing actual writing skills. Finally, mid-term and final presentations will allow participants to share their performance and outcomes. Reading and tutorial sessions will be assigned to increase knowledge about relevant issues, while in-class exercises and presentations will demonstrate how specific knowledge and methods presented in the course can be productively applied. Over the course of 13 sessions, participants will work together actively to achieve these objectives.

Course Description

Date	In-Class Activity	Assignment
Class 1 26 May (Tues)	Course and Teaching Team Introduction • Teaching Team & Self Introduction • Course Introduction	Research Interest with Five Manners (1 page)
	What is academic writing? • Design Brief vs Academic Writing Research Interest with Five Manners • What-Why-Focus-How-So What	
	Tutorial Group Development • Connect with your tutorial instructor	
Class 2 28 May (Thurs)	Basic Academic Writing Structure • Basic structure of academic writing Literature Review Basic 1 • Literature review diagram	Outline of Review • Systemic literature review process • Research keywords
	Tutorial Session • 4 groups with the assigned instructor(s)	
Class 3 2 June (Tues)	Literature Review Basic 2 • Systematic review process • Identify a research gap	Literature Review • Literature review (2-page word file)
	Tutorial Session • 4 groups with the assigned instructors	
Class 4 4 June (Thurs)	Guest Speaker: Anteja Klimek • Design Innovation & Venture Building at formlove	• Research gaps (1-page word file)
	Tutorial Session • 4 groups with the assigned instructor(s)	
Class 5 9 June (Tues)	Research Questions • From research gaps to research questions	• Research questions (1-page word file or visual diagram)
	Tutorial Session • 4 groups with the assigned instructor(s)	
Class 6 11 June (Thurs)	Mid-term presentation – Rooms R502 + R507 • Power Point (presentation part) • Word file (writing part)	Submit presentation + essay writing (thus far)
06/16 - 06/18	No class this week	
Class 7 23 June (Tues)	Methodology Review • Research Paradigms • Types of research approaches • Research questions to research methods • eSFQ (3:15-3:30pm)	Revision (mid-term feedback)
	Tutorial Session • 4 groups with the assigned instructor(s)	
Class 8 25 June (Thurs)	Methodology & Findings (qualitative) • Types of research methods • Data collection, analysis, and findings	Methodology • Research design by identifying research approaches (1-page word file)
	Tutorial Session • 4 groups with the assigned instructor(s)	
Class 9 30 June (Tues)	Methodology & Findings (quantitative) • Research methods (QCA / SEM / Experiment) • Data collection, analysis, and findings	Refine methodology • Research design by identifying research approaches (1-page word file)
	Tutorial Session • 4 groups with the assigned instructor(s)	
Class 10 02 July	Guest Speaker: Gordon SIU • Head of Advanced Strategic Design, Dongfeng	• Results + Conclusions (2-page)

(Thurs)	Nissan	word file)
	Tutorial Session • 4 groups with the assigned instructor(s)	
Class 11 07 July (Tues)	Optional tutorial to refine findings and conclusion, research essay and presentation	
	Tutorial Session • 4 groups with the assigned instructor(s)	
Class 12 9 July (Thurs)	Final Research Project Presentation – Rooms HJ302 + HJ304 • Presentation (in-class room) • Submit your poster + research essay	Final presentation + poster + essay submissions
Class 13 14 July (Tues)	Exam • Five questions and answers This will be an online exam, you do not need to come to class.	Exam

Basic Rules and Guidelines for Course Work

The following rules and guidelines have been established to ensure a fair and efficient assessment process for all students. Please read and adhere to them carefully.

Work Format:

- The default format for all assignments is to work in groups, preferably pairs (2 people) – these groups should be aligned to your capstone projects, and hence will be formed of the **same teams as your capstone cohort projects**. Large groups (4-5) should divide their teams into two with slightly different foci for their academic research and writing. Students are responsible for contributing equally to their assignments and submitting them by the assigned deadline. Tutorials are held in MDes cohort studios.

Use of GenAI Policy:

- It is strongly recommended that students refer to the [PolyU guidelines for students on the use of Generative Artificial Intelligence \(GenAI\)](#) for all assignments. The coordinator of this course believes that GenAI can help students generate high-quality text and enhance their writing skills, so we assume that all students will use GenAI tools, however it is essential that you are the design researcher ensure that your voice, critical thinking and research lead your academic writing.

Mid-term Presentation:

- Students are required to give a mid-term presentation, which should be clear, concise, and well-organised. The verbal and digital presentation will be in 5-7 slides cover all aspects of the first 5 classes including the initial stages of the 5 manners of research interest: 1. What – topic & issue, 2. Why – problems & motivations emerging from your Literature Review, and 3. Focus – research questions.

Final Poster Presentation:

- Students are required to present their project using a poster format, which should include the research question, methodology, findings, and conclusion. Students are expected to deliver an oral presentation and answer questions from the audience.

Course Assignment Structure:

- A1 Group – Mid-way presentation + research essay: 25%
- A2 Group – Final poster presentation + poster + research essay: 45% (2,500-3,000 words)
- A3 Individual - Exam: 15%
- A4 Individual Participation & Attendance: 15%

Please see the course rubric for assessment criteria.

Bibliography:

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Poster Guideline:

We recommend that students make use of the ISADR 2025, Taipei, Taiwan poster guideline <https://www.iasdr2025.org/submission-form.html#Poster-Papers>

Poster papers can report on work-in-progress or completed research. Poster papers should be 2500-3000 words long, excluding the abstract and references. Authors should demonstrate a high degree of academic scholarship or practical significance. Poster papers should clearly articulate the research focus, provide a concise synthesis of the research context, describe the methods used to undertake the research, present the research findings, and summarize the contribution to the field.

The papers should be written in English and follow the APA publication style for in-text citation and reference lists. Files should be submitted in pdf version, you can take inspiration from the IASDR [template](#).